

THE MISSING KIDS

Thousands of people have been kidnapped in the state in recent months, scores of them children. Despite the Patna High Court cracking the whip, the police remain clueless.



INCONSOLABLE:
Akash's mother
with her relatives
at a Patna police
station

Photographs by RANJAN RAHI

■ By Farzand Ahmed

Last week, in the midst of his *janata darbar*, Chief Minister Nitish Kumar summoned the state's director-general of police, A.R. Sinha, and asked, "DG *saheb*, where is Akash?" If he expected the police chief to give him some classified information on the whereabouts of the victim, then he was obviously wrong. For what came the DGP's reply: "Absolutely clueless, sir." That should have given the chief minister at least some clue about the state of lawlessness in Bihar which is back to basics once again.

A month on and the state police administration is still in dark about

Akash, alias Anshu, the Class VII student of a prestigious Patna school, who was kidnapped on August 10 by three masked men leaving the state capital under a cloud of fear. The kidnapping of Akash, son of Yogendra Pandey, a lab assistant in a government department, is not a lone case. It was preceded and followed by a series of such cases involving kidnappings of schoolchildren across the state. On August 11, seven-year-old Saurav, a Class II student of a public school and son of transporter Lalit Yadav, was kidnapped in flood-ravaged Saharsa while on August 9, Vibhishek Roshan, a Class VIII student, was kidnapped from Patna's Indira Nagar and killed for ransom.

Though state Home Secretary

Afzal Amanullah claims that during the one-and-half years of Kumar's rule, the number of kidnappings in general and that of children in particular has come down, leader of the Opposition Rabri Devi has urged the chief minister to take steps to end the menace if he really believes in the word "*sushasan*" (good governance).

The Patna High Court had asked the state administration in October 2005 to explain the measures it had taken to arrest the spate of kidnappings in the state. In fact, the high court used the kidnapping of Gaurav Kumar (Golu) on September 20, 2005 (on the eve of the Assembly polls), as reference point to order monitoring of the situation on a monthly basis by police. The